

It IS that Serious

A podcast pitch brought to you by Ava Groh

INTRO TO GENDER, RACE, & SEXUALITY 01:988:101:92

Background

In the current age of rapid-fire digital discourse, social media trends are often dismissed as "just a joke", "not that deep," or, "not *that* serious." However, language and humor *can* have significant meaning, and often even act as modes through which power dynamics, so ingrained in American society, are reinforced. My proposed podcast, *It IS that Serious*, seeks to help a young, uneducated audience—those who usually like and scroll without thought—think about how digital trends, slang, and modern social interactions are deeply rooted in heteronormativity and patriarchal structures.

The reason this podcast is important is that these influences and biases are almost invisible because they are so constant. Judith Lorber in "Night to His Day: The Social Construction of Gender" (1994:54) hits on this when she argues that gender is so "pervasive" that we just assume it's a biological fact "bred into our genes" rather than something society created. Because we've been taught to see heteronormativity as "natural," the micro-aggressions embedded in TikTok slang or even legislative debates usually go unchallenged. *It IS that Serious* is designed to bridge the gap between critical frameworks and the digital culture we live in day to day. I want to help listeners to confront and understand how their "casual" language actually contributes to a much broader system of oppression. In other words, this podcast is a tool for unlearning—a necessary intervention in a world where we've been conditioned not to ask questions. The following episode guide outlines how I plan to do this in the first three episodes.

Episode Guide

Episode 1: "Cracked": The Violent Language of Hegemonic Masculinity

This episode explores how the patriarchy is socially perpetuated through the evolution of sexual slang. Specifically, I want to talk about a recent TikTok term: "cracked" being used to describe sexual intercourse.

Episode Premise:

The term "cracked" is seen and used, primarily on TikTok, as a funny slang term, but where did it come from? Uncoincidentally, it follows a history of aggressive verbs—like "hit," "smashed," "banged," "pounded," "screwed"—that characterize sex as an act performed on or to a woman, rather than something she is a part of. This reflects what bell hooks (2004) and many others identify as a fundamental component of patriarchy: the requirement that men dominate. As hooks (2004) puts it in Chapter 2 of her book *The Will to Change: Men, Masculinity, and Love*: "patriarchy is a political-social system that insists that males are inherently dominating, superior to everything and everyone deemed weak."

Whether it's intentional or not, when we frame intimacy through violent metaphors, we are reinforcing what Michael Kimmel in "Masculinity as Homophobia: Fear, Shame, and Silence in the Construction of Gender Identity" (1994:125) calls "hegemonic masculinity." In his work, he explains that masculinity isn't a biological trait but a "constant pressure to perform" fueled by the fear of being seen as feminine or gay. This language is a form of patriarchal violence, which hooks defines as not just physical violence, but the psychological enforcement of dominance. In this episode, I will talk about how "cracked" isn't just a word; it's a linguistic micro-aggression that helps maintain the submission of women.

Episode 2: Off-Script: Why the State Fears Gender Performance, Ft. Special Guest Chase Strangio

Why is the general public—and in turn, the state—so bothered by the gender presentation of LGBTQ+ individuals when it has no direct impact on their lives? This episode investigates why transgender people are viewed as a threat to the social order and why homophobia is so often protected by government policy.

Episode Premise:

The discomfort surrounding LGBTQ+ identities stems from the fact that they expose gender as a performance or fashion rather than a biological truth. If gender is a "human production" (Lorber 1994:54), then trans individuals reveal the "man-made" nature of the entire social hierarchy. This episode will look at why the government uses restrictive marriage laws and anti-trans legislation to protect these traditional views

I will use Cathy J. Cohen's (1997) ideas in "Punks, Bulldaggers, and Welfare Queens: The Radical Potential of Queer Politics?" to look at how the state uses "heteronormativity" to decide who counts as a "worthy" citizen. Cohen (1997:440) argues that queer politics shouldn't just be about being "included" in the current system, but about challenging a system that punishes anyone who falls outside the "monogamous, middle-class, white" ideal. I want to ask: why are these individuals not treated as human? The answer ties back to Kimmel's (1994:125) idea that homophobia is really about the fear that other men will unmask us as "not manly enough." In this light, transphobia is just a tool for the state to enforce their binary "normality."

As an interview guest, I'd like to bring on Chase Strangio, Deputy Director for Transgender Justice at the American Civil Liberties Union and a leader in the fight against anti-trans legislation (Douthat 2025). Being also a transgender man himself, he can provide insightful connections between legal theory and his lived experience.

Interview Questions:

Question 1: How does the current surge in anti-trans legislation serve to reinforce traditional "hegemonic masculinity" for the voting base?

For this question, I want to dive into how the state uses what Michael Kimmel (1994:125) describes as the "constant pressure to perform" masculinity to fuel political agendas. I'm interested in how these anti-trans laws are marketed to voters as a way to "protect" a social order that is actually built on the fear of being seen as "weak" or feminine. I'd like for us to discuss how policing trans freedom is a way for the patriarchy to re-establish itself as a symbol of strength and virtue during a time of political uncertainty: something many listeners may not have thought about. I hope to gain insight into how legislative attacks aren't just about the individuals they target, but are actually a tool to reassure a specific voting base that the "traditional" man-made hierarchy is still in control.

Question 2: In what ways do you see the state using gender-policing to define who is entitled to "human rights" and who is not?

This question is inspired by Cathy J. Cohen's (1997:440) framework regarding how the state uses "heteronormativity" to decide who is a "worthy" citizen. Just as we've seen women of color be "queered" and stripped of their reproductive autonomy throughout history (Wolfe 2022),

there's certainly a similar pattern in how the state targets trans people today. I want to talk about how banning gender-affirming care or bathroom access is a way of "othering" a group to justify denying them basic human rights. Through this question/answer, I want to show my audience that when the government regulates how someone presents their gender, it's practicing a form of "patriarchal violence" that seeks to dominate and control bodies that don't fit a specific mold.

Question 3: How can we move toward what Cathy J. Cohen calls "liberatory politics" instead of just seeking "assimilation" into the existing patriarchal structures?

In many legal discussions, the focus is just on being "included" in the current system, but I want to look at Cohen's idea (1997:453) that true queer politics should challenge the whole system. If the system is designed to punish anyone—queer or heterosexual—who falls outside the "middle-class, white" ideal, then simply fitting in isn't enough. I'd like to hear your thoughts on how we can stop playing by the rules of a "man-made" hierarchy altogether. Insight Gained: I want this part of the interview to give my listeners the "tools necessary" to think beyond just "legal rights" and toward a total transformation of how our society values human life and identity.

Episode 3: Designed Deviance: How We 'Queer' Poverty

This episode will explore how race and sexuality intersect to create unique forms of "othering." It will look at how modern media still uses tropes of the "deviant" person of color to justify the withdrawal of social support.

Episode Premise:

Building on Cathy Cohen's "Punks, Bulldaggers, and Welfare Queens," this episode examines how the "moral panic" regarding gender and sexuality is often used to target poor people of color. Cohen (1997:453) points out that a single mother on welfare is often "queered" by the state—meaning she is treated as sexually deviant and outside the norm—even if she is heterosexual.

I'll also discuss how social media trends that mock "lower-income" lives/aesthetics are rooted in this same policing. When people laugh at "ghetto" or "hood" jokes, they are really participating in a system that labels certain people as "dysfunctional" to justify their oppression. As bell hooks reminds us, the "will to change" requires everyone to realize that patriarchy hurts us all, but it hits people at the intersections of race and poverty the hardest. This episode will challenge listeners to see that "queer" isn't just a sexual identity as many people think; it's also a position of being "at odds" with the power structures of the state.

Conclusion

Ultimately, my goal with *It IS that Serious* is to educate and spread awareness on how casual digital trends are not exempt from the influence of our society's deeply-rooted systemic oppression. By deconstructing our modern slang through frameworks such as Michael Kimmel's (1994) idea of hegemonic masculinity and bell hooks' (2004) definition of patriarchal violence, this podcast will help reveal that our language is a constant performance of male dominance. As Judith Lorber (1994) argues, gender is a pervasive "human production" that we often fail to see because it is so ingrained in our society.

I feel that this platform is necessary because it combines critical theory with everyday life to provide a new perspective on things many want to claim are "not that serious." By supporting

this podcast, you will be funding a discussion about overlooked issues and a movement towards the "liberatory politics" described by Cathy J. Cohen (1997), helping me provide my audience with the tools necessary to identify where systemic oppression and digital culture meet. There needs to be representation across all forms of media to challenge these unquestioned norms. It's time we, especially young people, recognize that when it comes to the power of our humor and language, it really *is* that serious.

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